

up. They give you a chance to remove the bloat-ware that came loaded with your phone, and you can choose to install what you want.

- **Over-clocking:** With the combination of a custom kernel and the right tweaks, even an over-clocked phone can give you a huge performance boost, which would otherwise be impossible to achieve.
- **Better theme support:** Customised ROMs may allow you to change the theme of your phone in ways that would have been otherwise impossible. Some heavily themed skins might even force you to forget that you are using Android!
- **New features:** Most ROMs provide innovative features and solutions to minor quirks, which can change the way you use your phone.

Before you start

Before you even think of flashing your phone, get ready with a list of things to do and the process to follow. The most important thing is backing up. You should not only back up your data (contacts, email, etc), but also your software, your current applications, settings and even the entire stock Android ROM that originally came with your phone. Who knows, if things do not work out, you might want to switch back to what you originally had. There are several back-up applications available, the best among them (according to me) being Titanium Backup. Even though it has a free version, it has so many innovative features that it is worth paying for the full version. What this app basically does is allow you to back up all settings and application data to the cloud or an SD card if available, and recover it across different ROMs. So settings, contacts and apps from your stock Android ROM will easily be available in the newly flashed ROM, with the help of this application.

Another must-have application for your phone is the ROM Manager. It basically allows you to browse and download different ROMs, install the latest ClockWorkMod recovery manager, and back up the stock Android ROM that came with your phone—which means that it is an all-in-one app that makes your life much easier.

All about recovery

One important thing you must know about before venturing into modding is that in most cases, your Android phone's internal memory is partitioned in the following way:

- *splash1*
- *boot*
- *recovery*
- *system*
- *cache*
- *data*

What's important here is the *recovery* partition, which contains the software relevant to the recovery mode your phone can boot into. The stock version allows you to

Must-have apps for your rooted Android phone

These are some of the apps that I have come to like. Some of them might be paid ones, but those mentioned here are worth it:

- *Tasker:* The best Android app you may ever encounter. It performs tasks based on contexts, i.e., you can trigger some actions when a particular situation occurs; this is much more powerful than you can imagine.
- *Kernel Manager Lite/Pro:* Allows you to swap kernels for your phone. The main attraction is the ability to over-clock your device and squeeze out extra battery life or some extra performance, according to whatever your priorities are. The app allows you to browse the different kernels available for your device, download them and then flash them to your phone.
- *setCPU:* This is one of those ubiquitous apps that you will find on most rooted phones. It allows you to over-clock, under-clock and tune the CPU of your phone.
- *Root Explorer:* As the name suggests, it allows you to browse the root filesystem of your phone, which most normal file explorers do not allow.
- *SuperUser:* This allows you to secure your phone by preventing unauthorised root access to your phone, with the help of superuser rights management.
- *Busybox:* This gives you access to some useful Linux or UNIX-based commands that are required for many root-level tasks.
- *Adfree:* An app that acts like the AdBlocker extension for your Android phone, as it blocks all Google ads from showing up in your applications.

And of course, the ones mentioned earlier, like Titanium Backup Pro and ROM manager, are also to be included in this list. Besides these, you might need a console app and a good keyboard that suits you.

reset your phone and reinstall the firmware. Now, in order to install most custom ROMs, we need to flash a custom version of our recovery manager, which allows us to do more than just reset our phone. One such popular software is the ClockWorkMod Recovery Manager, and installing it is as easy as installing the ROM manager app from the Android market. Then, to boot into this recovery mode, a special device-specific hardware key combination is used; you can easily look this up on the Internet. Most probably, the keys will be something like the 'volume up' or 'volume down' button that needs to be pressed while booting your phone.

A word about nAndroid backups is a must here. ClockWorkMod also provides an option for backup and recovery, among other features. This basically takes a complete backup of the memory and software in your phone, and copies it onto the SD card. So yes, you need enough free space there before attempting a nAndroid backup. Most developers suggest that you take a nAndroid backup every time you flash your phone.